Turnos vs. Merytu — Competitive Benchmark

Date: 2026-10-17
Subject: merytu.com — Portugal, hospitality gig marketplace (Lisbon, Porto, Algarve, Braga, Coimbra; 165+ localities claimed)
Status: Research. No product decisions taken from this yet.

> Same country, same sector, same customer — but Merytu's workers are **self-employed** (trabalhadores independentes, recibos verdes) and Turnos's are **employees of the company** on MCD contracts. Almost every difference below follows from that one choice.
>
> Merytu's figures are the ones **they or the press publish** and are not independently verified. Where this report estimates, it says so. Turnos comparisons come from this repository's code and ADRs.

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1. The difference that explains all the others

	Turnos	Merytu
Who the worker is to the company	An **employee** — MCD contract (art. 142.º CT)	An **independent contractor** — "não existe vínculo contratual connosco ou com a empresa"
Who owes Social Security	The company (23.75%) + worker (11%, deducted)	The **worker** alone (21.4% on 70% of income, after a 12-month exemption) + company pays 7–10% only if it is >50% of that worker's income (art. 140.º CRC, "entidade contratante")
What the worker must set up	Nothing — NIF + IBAN	**Open activity** at Finanças (Merytu automates it), give Merytu **sub-user access to their Portal das Finanças** to issue invoices in their name, own accident-insurance policy, own medical fitness certificate, quarterly SS declarations
Legal risk sits on	The company, as a normal employer	The **platform**, under the employment presumption of **art. 12.º-A CT** (Lei 13/2023) — and soon the **EU Platform Work Directive 2024/2831** (transposition deadline **2 Dec 2026**)

Merytu's pitch to companies is "no contracts, no paperwork, no Social Security" — the company buys hours. Turnos's pitch is "a legal contract, done in a click" — the company hires. Merytu is easier for the company today; Turnos is safer for both sides as the law tightens.

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2. Side by side

	Turnos	Merytu
Founded / stage	Beta, Lisbon	2021; ~85,000 registered workers, ~1,500 companies (Nov 2025)
Sector	Multi-sector (hospitality, retail, events, logistics, cleaning, admin)	Hospitality + events + spa. **Entering logistics/distribution (Q2 2026) and retail**
Funding	Bootstrapped	€1M pre-seed (Portugal Ventures, 2022) + **€1.5M (2026) from Banco Português de Fomento and Hotusa Ventures**
Expansion	Lisbon → Porto	Belgium and/or Spain, first move end-2026 / 2027

	Turnos	Merytu
Revenue model	€45/mo subscription + €3 per completed shift	No subscription. Company pays an **all-in hourly price** set by role + worker level; Merytu's margin is inside it (unpublished)
Minimum / maximum	2h minimum (enforced at creation), no maximum	4h minimum, 10h maximum per gig
Who chooses the worker	Company selects from applicants	Workers **accept the invitation**; reviews describe it as "fica com o Gig quem clicar mais rápido"
Wage flow	Company → worker directly. Turnos never holds wages	**Merytu collects** "em representação do Meryter" (100% captured at booking), pays the worker **weekly** via Santander; may SEPA-debit the worker for overpayments
Worker invoicing	Not applicable (salary)	Automatic fatura-recibo in the worker's name (Magnifinance); large clients get an aggregated invoice **in Merytu's name**, with taxes and contributions "included in the price"
Attendance	Check-in QR + 200m geofence; auto-completes	Check-in **and** check-out in app — both are conditions for the worker to be paid
Company cancellation	>24h free · 24h–3h counted · <3h reason required, 2h minimum wage if company error	>24h free · **<24h = 100% of the gig** (first day of multi-day). 10-minute grace after posting
Worker cancellation	≤24h strike; 2 strikes/30d = 7-day suspension; no-show 30-day suspension, 2nd = blocked	Yellow badge (<48h, visible 1 month), red badge (<8h or no-show, 3 months); visible to companies, slows level progression and **hourly rate**
No-show cover	None guaranteed	None — "a Merytu não assegura a sua substituição" (cl. 7.2, business terms)
Career mechanic	Ratings + badges	**Levels**: more gigs + good ratings = higher hourly rate
Insurance	Company's legal work-accident insurance (employee)	Marketing: "seguro gratuito incluído". Terms: "A Merytu não é titular de uma apólice… A responsabilidade da apólice é inteiramente do Meryter" — see §5
Role list	35 titles across 8 categories	~20 hospitality roles, finer-grained: empregado de balcão ≠ barman, sushiman, pizzaiolo, houseman, F&B host, bagageiro
App rating	—	3.8★ iOS (106 ratings)

3. Are they struggling to find workers?

Short answer: not in headcount. Their problem is the gap between registered and working, and the self-employed requirement is a large part of that gap.

What the numbers say

Date	Registered workers	Companies	Other
Jul 2022	1,200 (+200/month)	250+	1,200 invitations/day, accepted in <10 min
mid-2024	55,000	1,000+	**~€100,000/month transaction volume**, business +70% YoY
Feb 2025	60,000	~1,000	

Date	Registered workers	Companies	Other
Nov 2025	85,000 (+300% YoY)	~1,500	Revenue +118% YoY, team of 12

Estimate (ours, not theirs): €100k/month at a likely €11–14/h company price and a 4–8h gig is roughly **1,500–2,000 gigs a month** across 55,000 registered workers. Even with generous assumptions about gigs per worker, **only 1–3% of the registered base works in a given month**. And registrations grow ~3× faster (+300%) than revenue (+118%), so that ratio is getting worse, not better.

What the CEO says

- Feb 2025: "*Enquanto os profissionais são mais ativos, as empresas ainda se mostram mais recetivas*" — i.e. by their own account the constraint is **demand**, not supply.
- 2021 app review: the gig goes to whoever taps fastest. Dec 2025 review: "Trabalho não falta". Both are signs of a **worker surplus** chasing gigs, at least in Lisbon/Porto hospitality.

Where the self-employed model does hurt their supply

This part is reasoning from the legal mechanics, not something Merytu has published:

1. **Registration ≠ ability to work.** A registered user still has to open activity, link their Portal das Finanças, arrange insurance and a fitness certificate. Each step loses people. Merytu automating the activity opening is precisely the fix for their biggest leak.
2. **The month-13 cliff.** A first-time independent worker pays no SS for 12 months. In month 13 they start owing ~21.4% on 70% of their income (≈15% of gross) plus quarterly declarations. The cheapest, easiest Merytu worker is one in their first year — which builds churn into the pool at exactly the point a worker has become experienced.
3. **The pool self-selects.** It is easiest for people who are *already* independent, or who accumulate with an employee job at another employer (SS exemption under 4× IAS), or students in year one. It is hardest for the person hotels most want for rotation: the experienced professional who wants a few extra shifts but doesn't want to run a one-person business.
4. **Immigrants need the right permit.** Non-EU workers need a residence permit that allows *independent* activity (cl. 3, worker terms). Under MCD, an employee-type permit suffices.
5. **No fill guarantee.** Merytu explicitly does not replace no-shows and does not promise a fill rate. With a surplus of registered workers that suggests the bottleneck is *reliable* workers for *specific* roles, not bodies.

Conclusion for the pitch: don't say "Merytu can't find workers" — they will answer with 85,000. Say: **"85,000 registered, a few hundred working. Ours don't have to open a business to work a Saturday."**

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4. The legal comparison

4.1 Merytu's exposure — art. 12.º-A CT

Since 1 May 2023 a contract of employment is **presumed** between a worker and a digital platform when at least two indicators are present. Mapping them against Merytu's own terms and site:

Art. 12.º-A indicator	Merytu, as published
(a) Platform sets or limits the pay	Hourly price varies "por função, experiência" and **worker level**, which Merytu's progression system sets. Terms say the client sets the amount — the site says the level does

Art. 12.º-A indicator	Merytu, as published
(c) Controls / verifies quality of the work	Check-in **and** check-out required; payment conditional on a quality rating (cl. 4, worker terms)
(d) Restricts autonomy through sanctions	Yellow/red badges reduce visibility to companies and **slow the hourly-rate progression**
(e) Disciplinary power, incl. deactivation	Suspension/exclusion, 12-month re-registration ban, permanent exclusion (cl. 16)

Indicators (b) and (f) (direction of conduct, platform-owned equipment) look weak. Merytu's defences are real: the worker chooses whether, when and for whom to work, there is no exclusivity, and the CEO says there has been **no employment-recognition case since 2023** and that they "had to restructure some processes" when the law came in. The presumption also needs ACT or the worker to act. **This is a risk, not a verdict** — but it is a risk Turnos does not carry at all, because Turnos's workers already *are* employees (of the company).

4.2 What changes on 2 December 2026

The **EU Platform Work Directive (2024/2831)** must be transposed by 2 Dec 2026 — six weeks from this report. It (1) requires a legal presumption of employment where there is "control and direction", and (2) regulates **algorithmic management** for *everyone* doing platform work: transparency about automated decisions, human review, and no automated termination without explanation. Portugal already has 12.º-A, so (1) is mostly in place; (2) is new for both companies.

- Merytu: levels, badges and exclusion are automated decisions that will need explanations and human review. Their model of pricing-by-level is exactly what the Directive scrutinises.
- Turnos: already writes **statements of reasons** on every suspension/block (`users/restriction-notice.ts`), returns the **reason behind every match** (`skillMatch()` in shared) and offers human review in the privacy policy. That is a lead — worth checking against the final PT transposition text.

4.3 Three things in Merytu's terms worth knowing

1. **Insurance contradiction.** The site and app store promise "seguro gratuito incluído"; the worker terms (cl. 8, updated 19 Jun 2026) say Merytu holds no policy, only *facilitates access* to one (Generali), and that "a responsabilidade da apólice é inteiramente do Meryter". An accident on a gig is where that gap becomes a headline. Turnos's workers are covered by the company's mandatory work-accident insurance as employees.
2. **They hold the money.** Merytu captures 100% at booking and pays out weekly. That is a better worker experience than Turnos's direct payment (guaranteed weekly money), but it is payment-handling Turnos chose not to do (ADR 007) — and it puts Merytu squarely in the money flow of the work.
3. **"Clientes de Grande Volume".** For large clients Merytu invoices **in its own name**, with taxes and contributions included in the price. Selling labour hours under your own invoice is what a temporary-work agency does, and ETTs need a licence (DL 260/2009). **Question for the attorney, not a claim** — but if it holds, it is Merytu's soft spot with large hotel groups' compliance departments.

4.4 Turnos's own weak side in this comparison

Be honest about it in sales conversations — companies will raise it:

- **Cost.** Under MCD the company pays 23.75% TSU on top of gross; Merytu's company price is all-in. Turnos needs a calculator that shows *all-in hourly cost* next to the hourly rate.
- **Paperwork.** The company must admit the worker to Social Security itself before the shift (Turnos hands it the data; it doesn't file it). Merytu's company files nothing.

- **Caps.** MCD caps at 35 days/contract and 70 days/year with the same company. Merytu only sends a "recommendation" after 30 consecutive days.

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5. Where Merytu is ahead

	Merytu	Turnos
Scale and logos	85k workers, 1,500 companies; Marriott, Corinthia, Moxy, Mercure, Vila Galé, WOW	Beta
Distribution	**Hotusa** as shareholder (hotel group + Keytel network), Zomato partnership, hotel-school partnerships (ISCE), tourism job fairs	One landing page
Worker career	Levels that raise the hourly rate — a reason to stay	Ratings and badges, no pay progression
Weekly guaranteed payout	Platform pays every Wednesday	Depends on the company paying (with Turnos's enforcement ladder)
Cancellation deterrent	100% of the gig inside 24h	2h minimum only for company error under 3h
Role granularity	Balcão vs barman, sushiman, pizzaiolo, houseman	Broader titles (see recommendation on skills)
Company effort	No contracts, no SS admission	Company admits the worker to SS
No subscription	Pay per gig	€45/mo entry barrier (same finding as the Shifty report)

6. Where Turnos is ahead

	Turnos	Merytu
Worker status	Employee: SS covered, no business to run, no month-13 bill	Self-employed: opens activity, pays own SS, buys own insurance
Legal exposure	No misclassification risk — the contract *is* employment	Art. 12.º-A presumption + Directive from Dec 2026
Company chooses	Company reviews applicants and selects	First worker to accept
Wage-neutral fee	€3 fixed	Margin inside an hourly price — grows with the hour
Sectors	Retail, logistics, cleaning, admin live today	Entering logistics/retail in 2026
Algorithmic transparency	Reasons on every match and restriction	Levels/badges with no published explanation
Payment enforcement	Reminders, posting block, proof, dispute	Not needed — they hold the money
Attendance	One scan	Check-in + check-out

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7. What to do with this

1. **Lead the worker pitch with status, not price.** "Contrato de trabalho, não recibos verdes. Sem abrir atividade, sem Segurança Social para pagar ao fim de um ano, sem seguro para comprar." The month-13 cliff is the specific moment to recruit Merytu's experienced workers.
2. **Lead the company pitch with December 2026.** The Platform Work Directive is the reason to prefer a model where the hire is a contract. Pair it with an **all-in cost calculator** so the TSU objection is answered on the same screen.
3. **Steal role granularity.** Split hospitality roles where the skill gap is real (empregado de balcão vs barman/bartender). Feeds directly into the skills redesign.
4. **Consider worker levels with a pay signal** — not set by Turnos (that is an 12.º-A indicator *and* contradicts ADR 001), but shown to companies as "nível" so they can choose to pay more for it.
5. **Revisit late-cancellation pricing.** Merytu's 100%-inside-24h is the market's reference now; Turnos's 10% fee / 2h minimum looks soft next to it.
6. **Shift length 4h–10h (decided by Juanes, 2026-10-17, not yet built).** Raise the 2h minimum to 4h and add a 10h maximum, matching Merytu. Unlike Merytu's self-employed gigs, Turnos shifts are employment, so anything above 8h is overtime and a long shift needs a break — see the Labour Code check before building.
7. **Copy the supply channels, not the model.** Hotel schools, tourism job fairs and a hotel-group partner are how they got to 85k.
8. **Add two questions to the attorney brief:** (a) Merytu's "Grande Volume" invoicing as unlicensed cedência — relevant only as competitive positioning; (b) what the PT transposition of 2024/2831 requires from Turnos's own automated decisions (suspensions, ranking).
9. **Watch:** logistics/retail launch (now direct competition on Turnos's non-hospitality sectors), Belgium/Spain, and whatever Hotusa brings in distribution.

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